



# Namibia

Located in southwestern Africa, Namibia gained independence from South Africa in 1990, after 24 years of armed struggle. It regained the territory of Walvis Bay in 1994.



## GEOGRAPHY

The Namib Desert stretches along the coastal strip. Inland, a ridge of mountains rises to 8000 ft (2500 m). The Kalahari Desert lies in the east.



## CLIMATE

Almost rainless. The coast is usually shrouded in thick fog, unless the hot, dry *berg* wind is blowing.



## PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Ovambo, the main ethnic group, live mainly in the more populous north. Some 100,000 whites, many of German descent, are centered around Windhoek and still control the economy. The minority San and Khoi bushmen are among the oldest human communities in the world. The ban on homosexuality is contentious.



**INSIGHT:** *The Namib is the Earth's oldest, and one of its driest, deserts*



## THE ECONOMY

Varied mineral resources, notably uranium and diamonds. Rich offshore fishing grounds. High unemployment. HIV/AIDS epidemic. One of Africa's most skewed distributions of wealth.



## FACTFILE

**OFFICIAL NAME:** Republic of Namibia

**DATE OF FORMATION:** 1990

**CAPITAL:** Windhoek

**POPULATION:** 2.17 million

**TOTAL AREA:** 318,694 sq. miles  
(825,418 sq. km)

**DENSITY:** 7 people per sq. mile

**LANGUAGES:** Ovambo, Kavango, English\*, Bergdama, German, Afrikaans

**RELIGIONS:** Christian 90%, traditional beliefs 10%

**ETHNIC MIX:** Ovambo 50%, other 25%, Kavango 9%, Damara 8%, Herero 8%

**GOVERNMENT:** Presidential system

**CURRENCY:** Namibian dollar = 100 cents